

Had Cleopatra's nose been shorter, the history of the world would have been different, they say. But, really, does the nose matter so much? Ask cosmetic surgeons. No one has a better nose for what's inching up the nation's priority list. Young, professional, urban Indians are opting for surgical correction of the shape of the nose in ever increasing numbers, reports the Association of Plastic Surgeons (APS) of India, in the wake of a world congress of plastic, reconstructive and aesthetic surgeons last week in the capital. "Rhinoplasty is the most popular cosmetic surgery today," says Dr Suresh Gupta, president of the congress. The APS reveals that rhinoplasty has taken a giant leap of nearly 150 per cent in the last five years. That might very well be the tip of the iceberg. "The demand is much more," feels Dhir. He does about eight surgeries a month, gets 30-35 enquiries from people shopping around for the best price and 40-50 calls from those who are toying with the idea but haven't yet mastered the courage to go under the scalpel.

And they come in all shapes and sizes. On any given day, call in on a plastic surgeon and you will be taken aback by the range of patients filling up their chambers. Dr Narendra Pandya of Mumbai—who has corrected more Bollywood noses than one can count—would typically get a pretty young thing with an impossible list of demands ("I want Aishwarya Rai's bridge, Katrina Kaif's nostrils,

Kareena Kapoor's nose tip..."). In Delhi, for Dr Sunil Choudhary, head of aesthetic and reconstructive surgery at Max Healthcare, 70 per cent of the patients are "well-educated, new generation, independent, and most of them are getting it done out of their own pocket". According to Dr M.S. Venkatesh, head of plastic surgery at the Sagar Apollo Hospital, Bangalore, demand for lunch-time nose jobs from men between age 17 and 28 ("mostly professionals, students and aspiring models") is on the upswing.

"The only thing that's holding me back from feeling good about myself is my nose." Sitting on a stool at the plush Delhi Plastic Surgery Clinic, the young woman inspects her bulging nose in a hand mirror, the high-intensity lamp beating upon the very flat dorsum and very wide alar base. "I don't want to live the rest of my life hating the centre of my face. I am about to enter the real world. I need to look good," she continues. She wants to be an air hostess.

What has changed is not just the numbers, but the rationale behind a nose job. For the longest time, people sought nose corrections to reconstruct a deformed or damaged nose. Way back in 1958, Gupta recalls his first rhinoplasty as a young medic in Agra on a man whose nose had been chopped off by dacoits. Nose surgery just to improve one's appearance was far out of the mainstream when Pandya set up an aesthetic rhinoplasty practice in Mumbai way back in

Who Wants a Nose Job



Age is not an issue. Young adults opt for it as much as the 60-plus-busier-than-ever brigade. Most patients, however, are between 17 and 28, students or professionals.



Beauty premium at the workplace is real, say a rising number of men

pitching for a better nose. It's a "self-esteem" issue, they say, that gets in the way of career growth.



The craving for a well-defined nose, so long a Western obsession, has

caught on. While in the West, people seek to shorten, tilt or lower the nose, in India, everybody wants a sharp, pointy Roman nose.



The surge in rhinoplasty is backed by new treatment

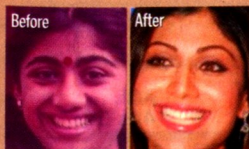
modalities: from finer suture materials, better implants to refined surgical techniques, especially the transition from 'closed' to 'open' rhinoplasty.



Primarily an elitist preoccupation, a nose job ranges from Rs 20,000 to

Rs 1.5 lakh, averaging at Rs 65,000. It's not just the moneyed; doctors see rising footfalls from across classes. Most are educated, young, independent people, choosing their own noses and paying for it too.

Nipping at your nose



Shilpa Shetty, actor

A rare celebrity who admits to a nose job, or two. Born with a flat nose, she decided to shave it down with plastic surgery early in her career. The effort has obviously worked for her.

Koena Mitra, actor

Peer pressure and the need to be perfect made her go for a nose job, one that went so wrong that it kept her indoors for months. A nose job is a gamble and can backfire badly, she says.

